

The Debate Over the Constitution

Map how Federalists, Anti-Federalists, small-state delegates, and supporters of a Bill of Rights argued over whether to ratify the new U.S. Constitution.

? Historical challenge

In 1787–1788, Americans fiercely debated whether to ratify the new U.S. Constitution. Supporters said the country needed a stronger national government; opponents feared it would trample state and individual rights. Investigate the arguments, then map how four different groups saw the same question.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

The Constitution of the United States – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The document itself; Article VII set the nine-state ratification requirement.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the Constitution require to take effect?
- Which parts might different groups worry about?

SOURCES 2

Federalist Papers: Primary Documents in American History – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 85 essays written by Hamilton, Madison, and Jay to urge ratification.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Who wrote the Federalist Papers, and why?
- What point of view do they argue?

SOURCES 3

The Ratification Debate on the Constitution – Bill of Rights Institute

SECONDARY SOURCE

How Anti-Federalist demands for a Bill of Rights shaped ratification.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did Anti-Federalists oppose the Constitution as written?
- How was the disagreement resolved?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.



Federalists (Hamilton, Madison, Jay, Washington)

S1

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

A stronger central government under the new Constitution to replace the weak Articles of Confederation.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

That the disorder, debt, and disunity under the Articles would cause the young nation to collapse.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Published the 85 Federalist Papers and argued at state ratifying conventions for quick approval.

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

The Federalist Papers (1787–88), written under the pen name 'Publius' — ① describe their arguments.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Won ratification and shaped the national government, but had to accept the promise of a Bill of Rights.



Anti-Federalists (Henry, Mason, S. Adams, R.H. Lee)

S2

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

To protect state powers and individual liberties and keep government closer to the people.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

A distant, too-powerful national government and possible tyranny.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Spoke against ratification in state conventions and published essays under names like 'Brutus.'

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

Anti-Federalist writings such as the 'Brutus' essays and George Mason's 'Objections' — ② describe them.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Lost the ratification fight but succeeded in forcing the addition of the Bill of Rights.

THE EVENT

Ratifying the U.S. Constitution

1787–1788

Philadelphia and the state ratifying conventions



Supporters of a Bill of Rights (swing delegates)

S3

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

Explicit written guarantees of rights such as free speech, religion, and trial by jury.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

That without listed rights, the new government could ignore individual freedoms.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Offered conditional support — agreeing to ratify only if amendments were promised (the 'Massachusetts Compromise').

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

State ratifying-convention records that attached recommended amendments to their votes.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Their demand produced the Bill of Rights, ratified in 1791.



Small-state delegates (New Jersey, Delaware)

S4

WHAT DID THEY WANT?

Equal representation so smaller states would not be dominated by larger ones.

WHAT DID THEY FEAR OR OPPOSE?

That a purely population-based Congress would leave small states powerless.

WHAT ACTION DID THEY TAKE?

Backed the New Jersey Plan and accepted the Great Compromise (equal Senate, population-based House).

WHAT EVIDENCE SUPPORTS THIS?

The Great Compromise written into the Constitution's two-house Congress.

HOW DID THE EVENT AFFECT THEM?

Gained equal Senate representation, which made ratification acceptable to smaller states.

Compare the voices

Where did perspectives overlap?

Where did they conflict?

Whose perspective is missing from the sources?

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- With a partner, compare your cards. Where did you record the same thing? Where did your evidence differ?
- Which group's perspective was hardest to find in the sources? Why might that be?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The Constitution needed nine of thirteen states to ratify (Article VII). Federalists (Hamilton, Madison, Jay) argued for it in the 85 Federalist Papers; Anti-Federalists (Henry, Mason, and writers like 'Brutus') feared centralized power and the lack of a Bill of Rights. The 'Massachusetts Compromise' — a promise to add amendments — won crucial states; the Bill of Rights was ratified in 1791. Whose perspective is missing? Enslaved people, women, and Native nations had no vote in the conventions.

Common misconceptions

- Anti-Federalists were not against all government — they wanted rights protections and stronger states.
- The Constitution did not originally include a Bill of Rights; it was added by amendment in 1791.
- Ratification was by special state conventions, not the state legislatures.

Vocabulary

ratification, Federalist, Anti-Federalist, Federalist Papers, Bill of Rights, Great Compromise, Article VII, civil discourse.

Historical context

Constitutional Convention May–Sept. 1787; ratification debates 1787–88; New Hampshire the 9th state June 21, 1788; first government 1789; Bill of Rights ratified Dec. 15, 1791.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was ratifying the Constitution the right choice for the new nation? Support your answer with evidence from at least two sources and at least two groups' perspectives.